



"If Abhishek goes off with someone, God bless him. I will be happy I made him a star. I am doing *Nach Baliye 3* only for him."

of Bollywood's highest paid stage performers.

Sawant may have been no more than an item girl in the 29 films she has done since 1999, but she is the star of her own daily saga, getting into trouble, losing her way and finding it again. Like the time an agent stole her passport instead of taking her to Dubai for work. Or when she learnt one should never go to a producer's house in the evening to "discuss a script". "I was just a girl. I knew nothing," she says. It's a hard-won independence that has taught her to think nothing of selling a Rs 16-lakh flat to buy herself three solitaires, because she wanted them, and pay for her make-up man's breast implants so that "she" could be happy with her boyfriend.

Sawant is a hoot but she is also an honest woman. In an industry where fakes of all kind—physical and emotional—abound, Sawant tells it like it is. Ask her about her latest release, *Buddha Mar Gaya*, and she calls it cheap, berating herself for having promoted the film. Quiz her about her

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boyfriend, struggling actor Abhishek Awasthi, and she says she prefers to live in with him in a three-bedroom flat she bought recently—her mother lives in her old flat. "It's not necessary that we will marry," she says.

Nothing in her background could have prepared her for this life in the limelight. She says: "My family was the kind where the women had big *mooche* (moustaches) and bushy eyebrows. They wore a *nath* (nose ring) and *ghunghat* (veil). The only TV we were allowed to watch was *Ramayan* and *Mahabharata*." Her father, a

Maharashtra police constable, walked out on the family when she was 12, and Sawant became the breadwinner, dancing in films and eventually doing a series of music videos for T-Series. "I was always a rebel. Music saved me. The minute I hear it,

I feel like dancing," she says.

Farah Khan, who cast her in *Main Hoon Na* as the school temptress, still remembers her as hard-working, punctual and well-mannered. "We covered her up because she was already so overtly sexy. It turned out she had very good comic timing," says Khan. Sawant would have remained just an item girl if she hadn't entered Sony's *Bigg Boss* last year. She didn't win the *Celebrity Big Brother* clone, but her full-on, in-your-face dramatics won her many fans. "People realised, *main jo dil mein hoon wahi parde par hoon* (what I am at heart is what I am onscreen)," she says. Sony Executive Vice-President Albert Almeida agrees: "Instead of the music video vixen, people saw her as a vulnerable woman trying to make it in a big, bad world."

Sawant is also a work-in-progress, regularly taking Botox injections to make her lips look fuller or to remove the fine lines she develops because of her workouts. She has so many surgery scars on her tiny body that she has adopted the best camouflage—six tattoos, from a heart on her collarbone to two dolphins on her back. She lives a disciplined life, playing squash between 10 and 11 in the morning, then a workout between 11.15 and 12.30 and cardio exercise between 12.30 and 1, before going to work. Sawant also makes time for an English tutor to come between her rehearsals and her shoots.

She invests the money she earns from live performances—up to Rs 10 lakh a day—in mutual funds and FDs. But though Sawant loves money, she won't do just about anything for it. She never accepts politicians' requests for private performances. "*Koi blouse noch lega, to koi kapde* (someone will strip your blouse, someone your clothes)," she says. She would like to be a two-in-one, Rani Mukherji and Mother Teresa, but what she really can become is a TV star, moving from *Nach Baliye 3*, which she has every intention of winning, to a forthcoming Zee TV chat show. She wants to start a chain of Rakhi Sawant Dance Academies throughout India. She believes in God, both Ganesh and Jesus. And in the *navgrah* bracelets she saw Kajol and Ajay Devgan wearing. "If it works for them, it should work for me," she says. That's Rakhi Sawant. What she wants, she gets. ■

"*Main angrezi seekh rahi hoon magar bolne se darti hoon* (I am learning English, but I'm afraid of speaking it)."